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# Governing a fragmented Wales

## Can Plaid deliver?

Plaid Cymru Conference 2026

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# 2026 – the ‘change election’

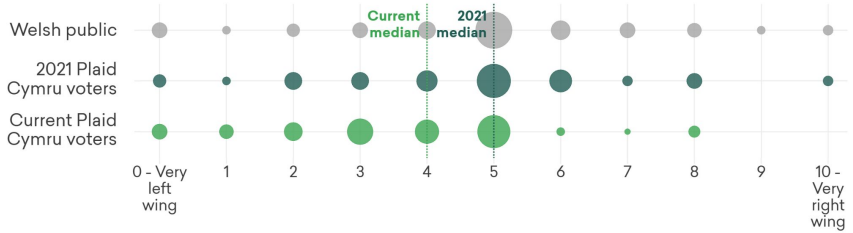
# Plaid Cymru won by building two voter bases

**Plaid Cymru was propelled by a widespread desire for change in Wales.** It held on to its traditional base of older, Welsh-speaking voters in the rural North and West - and added a wave of younger, urban defectors from Labour, comparable to Green voters in England.

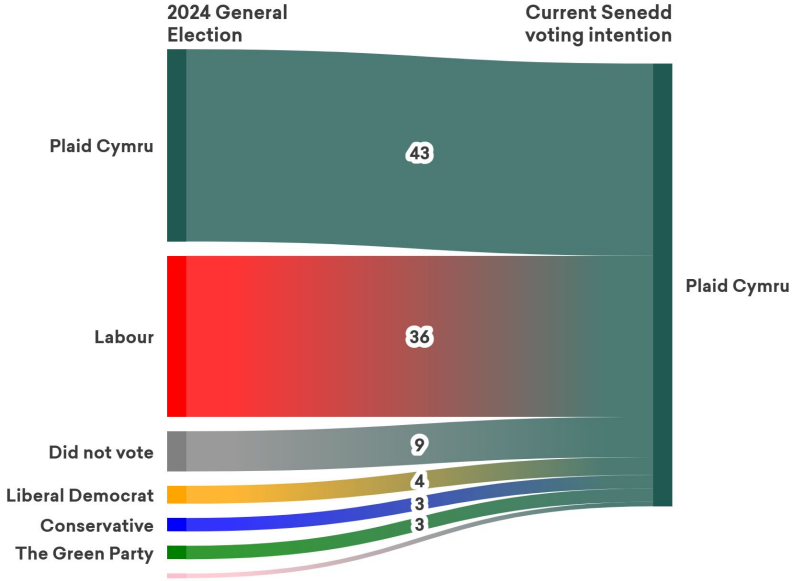
**As a result, Plaid's voter base has changed.** Its support is less closely tied to Welsh-speaking areas, its voters are more left-wing than in 2021, and its supporters are almost as likely to have voted Labour in 2024 (34 per cent) as Plaid Cymru (40 per cent). **The party now, in effect, has two voter groups to balance.**

## The average Plaid Cymru voter has moved to the left since 2021

Sometimes politics is described as being on a left-right scale. Where do you put your own views on that scale, where 0 is very left wing, and 10 is very right wing?




## More than a third of Plaid Cymru's supporters voted for Labour in the 2024 General Election




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Source: More in Common February 2026

# Voters wanted a bold voice for Wales

**Plaid Cymru won on a demand for a voice for Wales, and on progressives leaving Labour - and voters said they wanted it to be bold.**

## A voice for Wales, not independence

> *"It's like the SNP, they don't skip to what Westminster says. They're more looking inward towards their own part of Britain. So hopefully it's the same thing with Plaid."*
>
> **Jordan, Abergavenny**

> *"I'm hoping they'll be the Welsh voice in Westminster. I used to worry that they're all focused on pushing the Welsh language. I don't speak it."*
>
> **Neil**

> *"Independence sounds like a good idea. It sounds all patriotic and stuff. But would it actually be a good idea?"*
>
> **Alice, Abergavenny**

## Progressives leaving Labour

> *"There's a kind of idea about Labour in Wales now that is this elite political class that nobody's really in touch with. I feel Plaid are a more grassroots based kind of thing."*
>
> **Rod, Cardiff**

> *"I think Labour have burned their bridges, and what I would support would be Plaid, possibly with a Green coalition."*
>
> **Huw, Colwyn Bay**

> *"They aren't beholden to Westminster Labour in the same way Welsh Labour was, which may hopefully give them more freedom to do something different."*
>
> **Adele, Tredegar**

## Now, they want Plaid to be bold

> *"I'm feeling quietly optimistic and I would like them to be bold. If they're not bold, I worry that they will lose more ground to Reform in any future elections."*
>
> **Adele, Tredegar**

> *"I voted for Plaid this time and I'm really hopeful that we'll see some big change - and quite proud actually that Wales will have a voice."*
>
> **Lindsay, South Wales**

> *"They need to be ambitious, and I am feeling optimistic."*
>
> **Neil**

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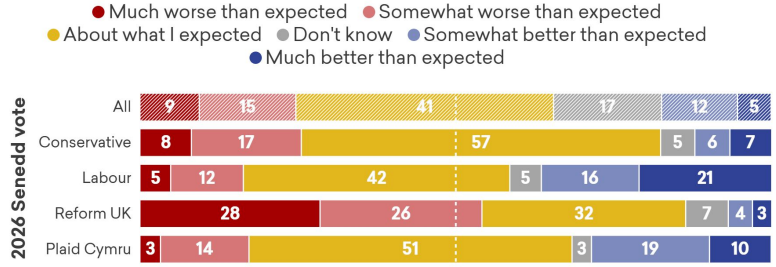
# Plaid's start to government

# Wales is still waiting to see

**A plurality of people in Wales say Plaid Cymru's time in government has been about what they expected (41 per cent)**, while 25 per cent say it has been worse and 17 per cent better. Seven in ten (70 per cent) say the new government feels like more of the same compared to the previous Welsh Labour government.

## Four in ten say Plaid Cymru's government has been about what they expected

Thinking about Plaid Cymru's time in government so far, would you say it has been...




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## In a word or two, how would you describe...?

Plaid Cymru




Reform UK




Labour




Conservative



# Rhun ap Iorwerth is not yet well known, but the public want to give him a hearing

**Five months in, many voters are still making up their minds about the First Minister. But he has clear strengths as a leader.**

Three in ten (30 per cent) don't know whether he is doing a good or bad job. His net approval in Wales (-3) is six points behind Andy Burnham (+3).

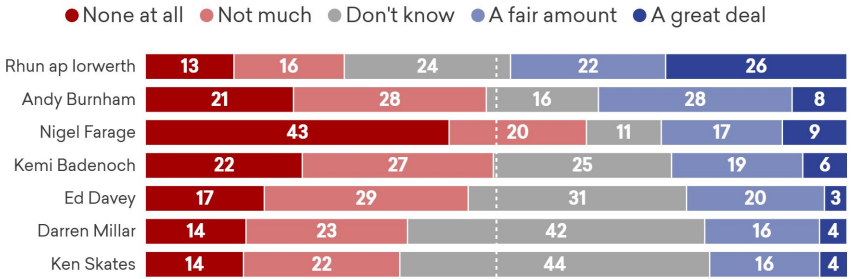
But where voters do know him, they often warm to him. He is the only politician tested who more people think respects the people of Wales than not (48 per cent to 28 per cent) - including majorities of Labour (68 per cent) and Conservative (52 per cent) voters, and a plurality of Reform UK voters (39 per cent)..

**In a word or two, how would you describe Rhun ap Iorwerth?**




## Rhun ap Iorwerth is the only figure seen to respect the people of Wales

For each of the following, how much respect do you think they have for the people of Wales?




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*"I didn't vote for Plaid, but I believe the leader is a patriotic Welsh man, and I feel he should do his best for Wales. So I'm quite optimistic for him."*

**Phil, Abergavenny**

# Popular policies, but struggling to cut through

**Okaud Cymru's opening policy agenda has been popular, but many of their most positive policies have gone under the radar.**

No policy or moment tested has been heard of by more than 54 per cent of people in Wales.

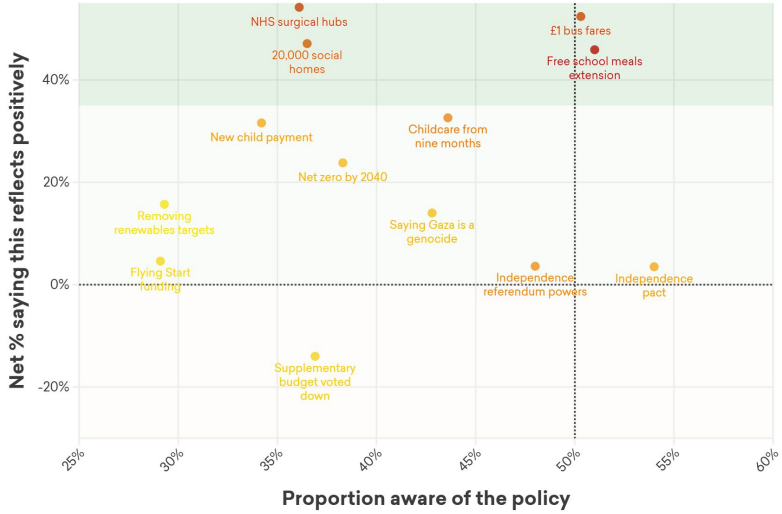
The best-known moves are constitutional - the independence pact (54 per cent) and the request for referendum powers (48 per cent) - and they split voters almost evenly.

**The exception is cost of living support:** free school meals (51 per cent aware, 58 per cent positive) and £1 bus fares (50 per cent, 59 per cent) are both well known and well liked.

But the best-rated pledge - promising up to 10 new NHS surgical hubs (60 per cent positive) - has been heard of by just 36 per cent. The supplementary budget defeat is the only moment seen more negatively than positively.

## Most of Plaid Cymru's early moves in government have been popular - but awareness is low

Lighter colours indicate greater ambivalence (more people expressing neither a negative nor positive view of the policy)




Source: More in Common (September 2026) • Net % saying this reflects positively = % saying incident either reflects very or somewhat positively - % saying it either reflects very or somewhat negatively

# Two key tests for this government

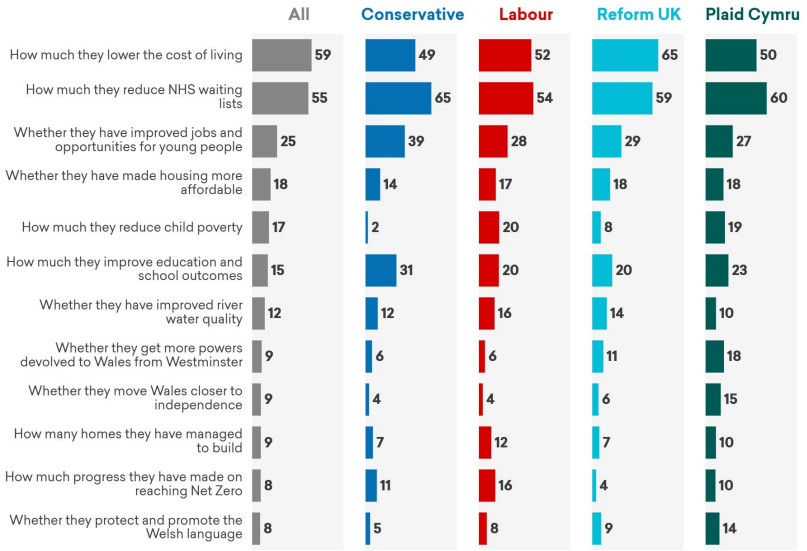
**Across every voter group in Wales, the public say they will judge the Plaid Cymru Government on two key tests: how much they lower the cost of living (59 per cent) and and how they reduce NHS waiting lists (55 per cent).** These are the top two priorities for Plaid Cymru, Labour, Reform UK and Conservative voters alike. They are well ahead of jobs and opportunities for young people (25 per cent), affordable housing (18 per cent) and child poverty (17 per cent).

**By contrast, few say they will judge the government on constitutional questions.** Fewer than one in ten say they will judge it on whether it moves Wales closer to independence (9 per cent), gets more powers devolved to Wales (9 per cent) or protects the Welsh language (8 per cent). Even among Plaid Cymru's own voters, only 15 per cent say independence will be one of their main tests.

## Voters across Welsh politics will judge Plaid Cymru on the NHS and cost of living

Which of the following will be most important to you in judging the success of this Plaid Cymru Government? Select up to three.

(By 2026 Senedd vote)




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# New: how would Wales vote today?

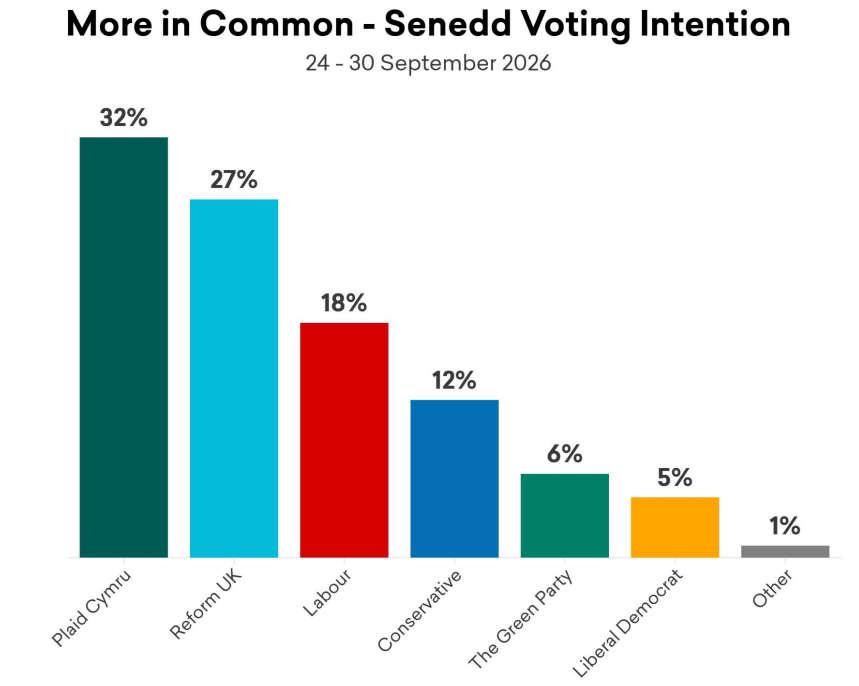
# Plaid Cymru hold their lead in the Senedd

**Plaid Cymru holds a five-point lead over Reform UK for the Senedd, five months on from winning May's Senedd election. Labour has recovered seven points since the election, while both Plaid Cymru (-3) and Reform UK (-2) have slipped back.**

For Plaid Cymru, this suggests that their honeymoon period has not dissipated: five months on, their vote share has only dropped by three points.

And while Labour's climb seems to suggest a 'Burnham Bounce', they have not recovered: an election held tomorrow would still be their second worst Welsh election in history.

- Plaid Cymru 32% (-3)
- Reform UK 27% (-2)
- Labour 18% (+7)
- Conservatives 12% (+1)
- The Green Party 6% (-1)
- Liberal Democrats 5% (+1)

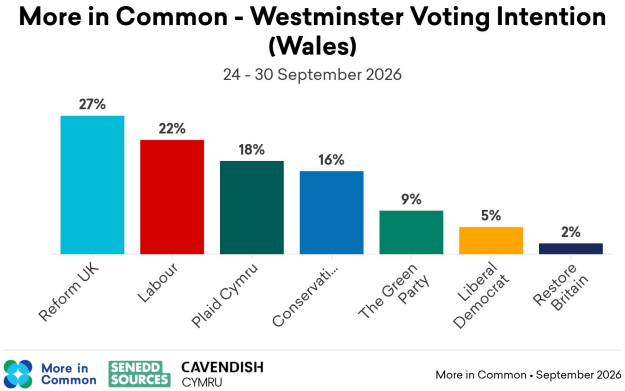


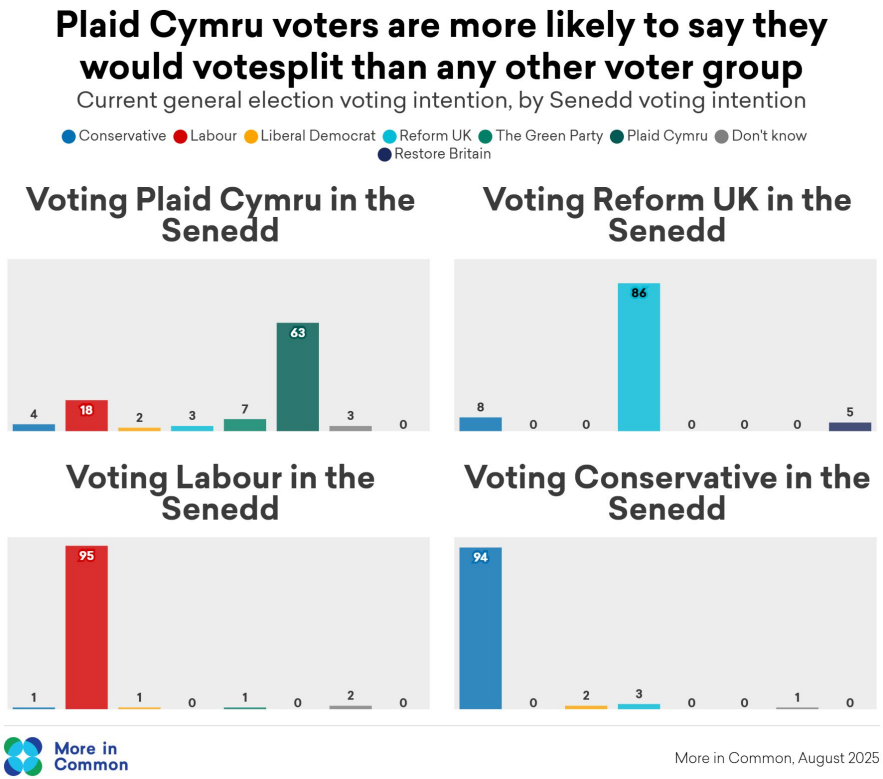
# But the ‘Burnham Bounce’ could split Plaid’s vote in Westminster

**Labour polls four points higher in Wales for Westminster (22 per cent) than for the Senedd (18 per cent), largely because Plaid Cymru voters split their vote.**

Only 63 per cent of those backing Plaid for the Senedd would vote Plaid at a general election. Almost one in five (18 per cent) would vote Labour, and 7 per cent Green. Other parties keep their voters: more than nine in ten Labour (95 per cent) and Conservative (94 per cent) Senedd voters back the same party at Westminster, as do 86 per cent of Reform voters.

This is the Burnham bounce at work. Andy Burnham is popular with Plaid voters (+37), and at Westminster he is drawing back some of the progressives Plaid won from Labour.




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# Diolch yn fawr!